about her desires and the choices she would like to make, and then invariably admitting that none of it will happen since the choices have been made for her.

What her parents have decided to do is to marry her off to someone from the same caste, in fact with the same surname, living in the area where she was born. Her family is Hindu and Brahmin, and it is inconceivable to her parents that she would marry outside the caste. In India, democratic freedom rubs up regularly against traditional social models, such as the caste system and arranged marriages, which continue to play a significant role in shaping relationships and even economic ties.[6] I ask Sita whether she will go back to the north, to the poverty-riven state of Bihar where her husband-to-be lives. Yes, she answers, for the marriage. And what will she do there? She doesn't know. A job? She shrugs. But, she hastens to add, arranged marriages remain extremely popular in India, and they are the best way to ensure that marriages succeed. In the West, she believes, too many people divorce and never commit to making married life work. She makes marriage sound like a duty, and when I tell her that, she doesn't disagree.

I ask if she thinks she will come to love her husband. She answers that she doesn't know, since she doesn't know him. She has only met him once, when her family traveled to a city near his hometown to meet him and his parents. The two of them never talked directly, but only in a large crowd of relatives, as is common in the negotiating stage of arranged marriages. "How can I love someone I've never talked to?" she asks. Perhaps he feels the same way, I add, but she just shakes her head. He is thirty-three, she tells me, ten years older than she is, and eager to get married.

The pressure on Sita to get married is not only due to traditional Indian mores. The past decades have seen the birth of far more males than females in India, not only in poor areas but in richer regions as well. Traditionally, boys were more valued for their labor potential in this overwhelmingly agrarian country, as in China, leading to sex-based abortion and infanticide. India's most recent census, which revealed an astonishing net gain of 180 million persons from 2000 to